

Trilemma

Three characters. Nine cells. Too many rules. · 1 to 8 players · about 30 minutes

Goal

Nine rule cards are face up, and they contradict each other. Be the fastest to find the largest group of cards that can all be true at the same time, bid that number, then prove it on the board. The player who has won the most cards at the end wins.

Components

- 55 rule cards (base deck) and 36 expert cards (marked EXPERT), all with the same back.
- 1 board: a 3 × 3 grid. Rows are numbered 1 to 3 from top to bottom, columns are lettered A to C from left to right. Corners and center are dark cells, with stripes; the others are light.
- 3 characters: the Star (one eye), the Circle (two eyes) and the Square (three eyes).
- 8 order tokens, numbered 1 to 8.
- Bid tiles numbered 1 to 9, one row per player.
- Optional: a timer (sand timer or phone).

The golden rule

A valid arrangement puts the 3 characters on the board with exactly one character per row and one per column. A group of cards is compatible when one arrangement makes all of them true at the same time.

Setup

1. Put the board in the middle of the table, with the 3 characters next to it.
2. Shuffle the rule cards (base deck only for the first games) into a face-down draw pile.
3. Deal 9 cards face up in a 3 × 3 grid.
4. Put one order token per player in the middle, from 1 up to the number of players.
5. Each player takes a row of bid tiles.
6. Decide together whether you play with a timer, and for how long. Without a timer, the search ends when everyone is ready.

A round

1. Search. Everyone searches at the same time for the largest compatible group. Nobody touches the characters.
2. Lock in. When you are done, put the bid tile of your number face down in front of you and take the lowest order token still available. Your bid can no longer change. When the timer runs out, the players who are not ready bid at once and receive the remaining tokens at random.
3. Reveal. Everyone turns their bid tile over at the same time.
4. Order. The highest bid demonstrates first. Ties go to the player who locked in first (lowest order token).
5. Demonstration. The player places the 3 characters on the board, then shows exactly as many cards as they bid, one by one. The other players check each card. All or nothing: one false card, or one card missing, and the whole demonstration is void. The next player in the order then demonstrates from scratch, with their own bid. If every announced card is true, the player wins those cards.
6. Refill. Return the order tokens to the middle. The other cards stay where they are; deal new cards into the empty slots, back to 9. If every demonstration failed, nobody scores and the same cards stay for a new search.

End of the game

The game ends when the draw pile is empty and no card is left face up. Each player scores 1 point per card won. The highest score wins; tied players share the victory.

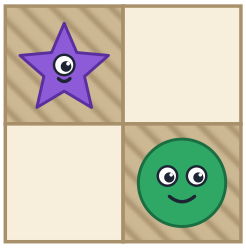
Solo

Play the same rounds and try to empty the deck in as few rounds as possible. Perfect play takes about 9 rounds with the base deck.

Reading the cards

- “Above”, “below”, “to the left of” and “to the right of” mean any distance: 1 or 2 rows or columns.
- Two characters are never in the same row or column, so “touching” always means touching at a corner.
- “Neighboring rows” means exactly one row apart.
- Expert cards talk about “the character in row 1” or “in column A”: whoever stands there.
- The number in the corner of each card is only there to sort the cards.

47



The Star and the Circle touch at a corner.

Touching at a corner

Printing and assembly

- Print in color on A4 paper, at actual size (100%, never “fit to page”).
- Cards (files 1 and 2): use thick paper (160 to 250 g/m²) if you can. Then put the printed sheets back in the printer and print file 3 (backs) on the other side of each sheet. The grids are centered, so the backs line up whichever way the sheet is flipped. Without thick paper: print on plain paper and slide each card into a standard card sleeve (63.5 × 88 mm) in front of an old playing card.
- Cut the cards along the crop marks, ideally with a paper trimmer, or with a ruler and a craft knife (adults only).
- Board (file 4): thick paper, or glue it on cardboard.
- Characters (file 5): cut out the flat tokens or the standees. Fold the standees along the dotted line.
- Tokens (file 6): order tokens and bid tiles. Print page 2 only for more than 4 players.